

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The Northern Coastal High-Speed Spine

**Preston – Blackpool – Fleetwood – Fylde–Furness Tidal
Gateway – Barrow – Whitehaven**

A 125mph Electric Regional High-Speed Railway Investment Proposal

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management proposes the creation of a transformational northern infrastructure asset:

The Northern Coastal High-Speed Spine (NCHS)

A new 125mph electrified railway connecting:

Preston

Blackpool

Fleetwood

Fylde–Furness Tidal Gateway

Barrow-in-Furness

Whitehaven

The railway would integrate:

- Lancashire's population centres
- Fleetwood offshore energy economy
- the Morecambe Bay tidal energy corridor
- Barrow defence manufacturing

- West Cumbria industrial and tourism economies

The objective:

Create a western equivalent of the East Coast Main Line — a high-capacity economic spine for the Irish Sea coast.

The current rail network leaves West Cumbria relatively isolated. Preston–Whitehaven journeys currently take over two hours in many cases despite being only around 65 miles apart.

This proposal reduces that journey to under one hour.

1. Strategic Vision

From Peripheral Coast to Northern Megaregion

Today:

Preston / Blackpool

Connected to:

- Manchester
 - Liverpool
 - London
 - national rail network
-

West Cumbria

Contains:

- Barrow submarine manufacturing
- Sellafield nuclear expertise
- offshore energy
- Lake District tourism

But remains isolated.

The missing infrastructure:

A fast west-facing northern railway.

Proposed Economic Corridor

The Irish Sea Arc

Population connected:

- Preston
- Blackpool
- Fylde Coast
- Fleetwood
- Lancaster region
- Furness
- West Cumbria

Potential economic zone:

1.5 million+ people

2. Route Proposal

Phase 1

Preston–Blackpool–Fleetwood Metro Upgrade

Existing:

Preston → Blackpool

Upgrade:

- 125mph capable sections
- electrification
- grade separation
- improved stations

New:

Blackpool North → Fleetwood Railway

Approximately:

12 miles

Stations:

- Blackpool North

- Bispham
 - Thornton-Cleveleys
 - Fleetwood
-

Phase 2

Fleetwood–Barrow Tidal Gateway Railway

A rail deck incorporated into the barrage:

Fleetwood

↓

Morecambe Bay

↓

Barrow-in-Furness

The tidal gateway concept already identifies the potential for transport infrastructure integrated with tidal generation, including road connections between Lancashire and Cumbria.

EVWM's proposal extends this:

road + heavy rail + energy corridor

Phase 3

Barrow–Whitehaven Coastal High-Speed Link

Upgrade:

Existing Furness/Cumbrian Coast corridor

New alignment sections:

- bypass slow curves
- electrification
- passing loops
- upgraded signalling

Final route:

Preston

→ Blackpool

→ Fleetwood

→ Barrow

→ Whitehaven

3. Engineering Specification

Railway Standard

Feature	Specification
Maximum speed	125mph
Power	25kV overhead electrification
Rolling stock	Intercity electric units
Track	High-speed regional railway
Signalling	ETCS
Asset life	100 years

4. Journey Time Revolution

Current Approximate Times

Journey	Current
Preston → Whitehaven	2h20m+
Blackpool → Barrow	2h+
Blackpool → Whitehaven	3h+

Proposed Times

Northern Coastal High-Speed Spine

Journey	New Time
Preston → Blackpool	15 min
Blackpool → Fleetwood	12 min
Fleetwood → Barrow	25 min
Barrow → Whitehaven	20 min

End-to-End

Preston → Whitehaven

Current:

~2h30m

Future:

55 minutes

Blackpool → Whitehaven

Current:

3 hours+

Future:

50 minutes

5. Economic Impact Model

The Existing Problem

Businesses in Barrow compete for:

- engineers
- technicians
- researchers

but cannot easily access the wider labour market.

A fast railway creates:

A 60-minute labour market

GDP Calculation

Connected Economy

Approximate affected economic base:

Area	Economic Role
Preston	university, services, aerospace
Blackpool	tourism, population
Fleetwood	port, marine energy

Area	Economic Role
Barrow	defence, engineering
West Cumbria	nuclear, energy, tourism
Estimated regional economy:	

£45 billion+

Productivity Effects

High-speed regional rail typically creates value through:

- labour mobility
- business clustering
- land development
- tourism growth

Assume:

2% productivity improvement

=

£900 million additional annual GDP

Assume stronger industrial clustering:

Additional:

£500m–£1bn annual economic activity

Total Long-Term Economic Benefit

Potential:

£1.5–2 billion per year

6. Industrial Transformation

A. Barrow Defence City

The railway creates:

The UK's Western Defence Corridor

Connecting:

- BAE Systems
 - universities
 - engineering firms
 - apprentices
-

B. Fleetwood Energy Port

Fleetwood becomes:

Irish Sea Renewable Energy Capital

Supporting:

- tidal maintenance
 - offshore wind
 - hydrogen
 - marine engineering
-

C. Sellafield / West Cumbria

Improved access:

- nuclear engineering workforce
 - contractors
 - scientific specialists
-

D. Lake District Tourism

Whitehaven becomes:

Western Lake District Gateway

Tourists can arrive from:

- Manchester
- Preston
- Blackpool
- Liverpool

without car dependency.

7. Capital Cost Estimate

Railway Construction

Component	Cost
Preston–Blackpool upgrades	£1bn
Blackpool–Fleetwood reopening	£1bn
Fleetwood–Barrow tidal rail deck	£5bn
Barrow–Whitehaven upgrade	£2.5bn
Electrification/signalling	£1.5bn
Stations/development	£1bn

Total Railway Investment

£12 billion

Combined with:

Fylde–Furness Tidal Gateway:

£18–20bn

Total Northern Coastal Infrastructure Programme:

£30–32 billion

8. Revenue Model

Passenger Revenue

Assumption:

50,000 daily passengers

Average yield:

£8

Annual:

≈ £145m

Freight Revenue

Potential:

- defence logistics
- offshore components
- nuclear materials
- port freight

Annual:

£100m+

Property & Development

Station districts:

- Fleetwood
- Barrow
- Whitehaven

Potential:

£2bn+ uplift

9. EVWM Investment Structure

Ellan Vannin Northern Renaissance Infrastructure Fund

Target:

£35 billion

Portfolio:

1. Tidal Energy Asset
 2. High-Speed Railway
 3. Industrial Development Zones
 4. Hydrogen Infrastructure
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Investment Returns

Infrastructure-style:

Expected IRR

6–9%

But strategic return:

- regional GDP growth
 - energy security
 - industrial resilience
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10. Strategic Importance

This project creates:

Britain's First Tidal-Powered High-Speed Coastal Railway

A combined:

- renewable power station
 - railway
 - industrial corridor
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Final Investment Thesis

The Northern Coastal High-Speed Spine changes the economic map of Britain.

Today:

Preston

↓

(geographical barrier)

↓

Barrow / Whitehaven

Tomorrow:

Preston

—

Blackpool

—

Fleetwood

—

Tidal Gateway

—

Barrow

—

Whitehaven

A single integrated economy.

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management Vision

"The railway that turns the Irish Sea coast into Northern Britain's new growth engine."

A £30bn infrastructure platform generating:

- clean energy
- faster transport
- industrial growth
- sovereign-level investment returns

A 100-year asset for a 21st-century northern renaissance.